



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Delaware Valley Classical School

School Website: <https://www.delawarevalleyclassicalschool.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Delaware Valley Classical School (DVCS) in New Castle, DE 19720 presents a robust, clearly classical trajectory aligned with the core Six Essential Elements of Classical Education. Public materials describe a Christ-centered, classical curriculum built on the grammar–logic–rhetoric progression, a strong emphasis on Great Books and the Western canon, intentional formation of virtue, and a pedagogy that blends contemplative, memory-rich lower grades with Socratic discourse and rhetoric in the upper grades. The school highlights Great Books, classical languages (Latin, Greek), a house-system culture, and formal mentorship, all under a Biblical worldview with explicit theology components. These features collectively map strongly to the classical rubric, suggesting a CLASSICAL overall evaluation.

Key signals across the six categories include: - Religious and metaphysical foundations anchored in Christendom and theology, with explicit Bible memory, hymnody, liturgical rhythm, and systematic theology emphasis. Evidence spans kindergarten "Christ-centered education," Bible memory, and theology-forward upper-level instruction.

- Purpose and goal centered on formation, virtue, and the good life, not merely job prep, with crisp statements about training to love truth, goodness, and beauty, and to pursue Christ and His Kingdom. - Curriculum built on the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium, plus Great Books/Great Conversation, history-driven across grades, and an emphasis on wonder. Latin/Greek instruction and integration with theology are highlighted.

- Pedagogy explicitly includes contemplative/restful learning, memory- and singing-rich lower grades, and upper-grade Socratic discussion and rhetoric training. - Faculty described as model teachers, living curriculum, and mentors; there is a formal leadership structure (Head of School, Logic & Rhetoric Principal, Grammar Principal) and ACCS/NCPSA accreditation reference. - Parents and community engagement framed as partnership with families, co-education, and ongoing education for parents (e.g., blogs, resources, and grandparent-focused content).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Christ-centered education and classical Christian framework are repeatedly stated (Kindergarten: "Christ-centered education in the classical tradition"; upper-level statements emphasize forming by Christ and a biblical worldview).
 - The curriculum foregrounds theology and apologetics (e.g., "Systematic theology and apologetics").
 - The public materials reference liturgical/religious practices (hymns, Bible readings) and a religious formation aim (center souls on Christ).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, Bible memory, theology, worship/hymns, Systematic theology, biblical worldview, formation in Christ, liturgical rhythm.

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- Negative keywords present: None evident in public text (no explicit secular relativism or value-neutral framing observed in these materials).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 8, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed relevant terms).
 - Why this rating
 - The explicit articulation of Christian formation, biblical study, and theology-centered culture aligns with the “Grounded in Theology” and “Liturgical and Communal Practices” dimensions of the classical rubric. The materials consistently present the transcendental realities of truth, goodness, beauty in a theologically informed frame, not a secular or relativistic orientation. This yields a CLASSICAL designation for Element 1. See examples of Christ-centered language and theology emphasis in Kindergarten and upper-school materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school describes education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not mere information or job preparation; explicit language about “the good life” and loving truth, goodness, and beauty appears in core public materials.
 - The Great Books/great conversation framework and the integration of virtue in formation are repeatedly emphasized.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, “good life,” human excellence, transcendence, character formation, love of learning.
 - Negative keywords present: None evident (no emphasis on mere job-readiness or market-driven outcomes in public materials).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 9, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed terms).
- Why this rating
 - The materials consistently articulate an aim of shaping character and intellect toward human excellence and the true/good/beautiful, rather than standard career-centric outcomes. This strongly matches the Classical category for Element 2. The explicit “live the good life” and love of truth/goodness/beauty language supports a CLASSICAL rating. See material describing formation, the good life, and virtue-oriented aims.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric framework is central (Kindergarten, Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric stages). The curriculum emphasizes the Seven Liberal Arts with grammar/logic/rhetoric, plus Latin/Greek; Great Books and the Great Conversation appear in program descriptions.
 - History is studied throughout the curriculum; the school emphasizes the Great Books and Western Civilization as part of a unified curriculum.
 - The school highlights “formed by the Great Books of Western Civilization” and “dual enrollment” with Cairn University, signaling a historically anchored and rigorous liberal-arts approach.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, classical languages (Latin/Greek), primary sources, unity of knowledge, wonder, integrated curriculum, formation through the arts.
 - Negative keywords present: None clearly observed (no explicit mention of non-classical or fragmented, secular, or utilitarian curricula).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 12, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed terms).
- Why this rating

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- DVCS’ explicit structuring around the Seven Liberal Arts, the Great Books program, the integration of history across the curriculum, and the emphasis on wonder and formation strongly align with Element 3’s classical curriculum criteria, yielding a CLASSICAL rating. See references to the grammar/logic/rhetoric progression and Great Books emphasis.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - A mixed pedagogy is described: lower grades emphasize singing, memorization, and restfulness; upper grades employ Socratic discussion and rhetoric training. The pedagogy explicitly accommodates both contemplative/restful and rigorous intellectual work.
 - Upper-school pedagogy includes Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training; lower-school pedagogy emphasizes memory, singing, and delight in the learning process.
 - The use of the Socratic method is explicitly identified as a core teaching technique, even noting its historical use in advanced contexts.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic method, Socratic discussion, memory, chanting/singing, contemplation, rest, unhurried curriculum, rhetoric training, public speaking, joyful learning, memory-focused recitation.
 - Negative keywords present: None observed (no modern, de-emphasizing approaches observed in public materials).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 9, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed terms).
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogical approach expressly marries contemplative/restful learning with rigorous Socratic and rhetorical training, consistent with classical pedagogy expectations. The explicit dual-track pedagogy (lower vs upper school) and focus on memory, singing, and Socratic discourse supports a CLASSICAL rating for Element 4. See lower-grade singing and memory emphasis and upper-grade Socratic/rhetoric emphasis.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty structure includes named leaders (Head of School, Logic & Rhetoric Principal, Grammar Principal) and a publicly stated number of upper-school faculty; the school emphasizes that faculty are cultivators of minds and hearts and that the faculty constitute the living curriculum.
 - Accreditation and faculty quality signals (ACCS and NCPSA) suggest alignment with classical-school expectations around faculty caliber and institutional formation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, formation of character, faculty as core of school, collegiality, credentialed teachers, focus on virtue and skill.
 - Negative keywords present: None observed (no references to low-stature or instrumental staff placeholders).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 6, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed terms).
- Why this rating
 - The explicit emphasis on faculty as living curriculum and mentors, plus named leadership roles and accreditation, maps well to Element 5’s expectations of a virtuous, capable, and formative faculty. This yields CLASSICAL for Element 5. See Head of School and faculty structure, and “living curriculum” language.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - A central emphasis on partnerships with families, parent involvement as co-educators, and community formation is evident in the public materials; the school explicitly positions parents

as partners and offers education for parents (e.g., grandparent-focused content and blog posts about classical education).

- The presence of parent/family engagement resources and the house system culture reflect a strong community dimension (houses, service, mentorship).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families, parent involvement, co-educators, home-school collaboration, parental formation, community partnership, family catechesis, grandparent engagement.
 - Negative keywords present: None evident (no “independence from families” or “teacher-only governance” signals observed).
 - Estimated keyword balance: Positive 7, Negative 0 (100% positive among observed terms).
- Why this rating
 - The public materials consistently emphasize family partnership and parental formation as integral to classical education, which aligns with Element 6’s expectations. The DVCS materials present a strong, positive community orientation and explicit parental engagement, supporting a CLASSICAL rating. See the explicit language on partnerships with families and parent resources.

Overall Assessment and Aggregate Ranking

- Across all six categories, DVCS demonstrates a coherent classical orientation with explicit evidence of transcendental foundations, formation-focused goals, a liberal-arts curriculum anchored in the Great Books, a pedagogy combining contemplative and Socratic elements, a living-faculty framework, and a robust parent/community partnership. Therefore, the aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- The school currently presents a strong classical profile with limited signs of deficit in the rubric. If a needle-moving step were considered, it would be to more explicitly document and quantify the Great Books list and the specifics of the Quadrivium components in the public-facing materials, to further demonstrate the depth of Great Books/Quadrivium engagement and the breadth of the Great Conversation across grades. Additional public statements about history/humanities integration across disciplines (beyond explicit mentions) could further reinforce the “integration and wonder” criteria at scale.
- Concrete steps (if aiming for a more explicit CLASSICAL alignment across all potential rubrics):
 - Publish a publicly accessible, cross-grade Great Books syllabus with primary-source selections and corresponding discussion prompts.
 - Provide a concise articulation of how the Quadrivium is structured within the middle/upper school programs (arithmetic/geometry/music/astronomy) and how these are integrated with other subjects.
 - Expand parent education programming with more systematic, regular offerings (book studies, lectures) to reinforce the partnership with families as co-educators.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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